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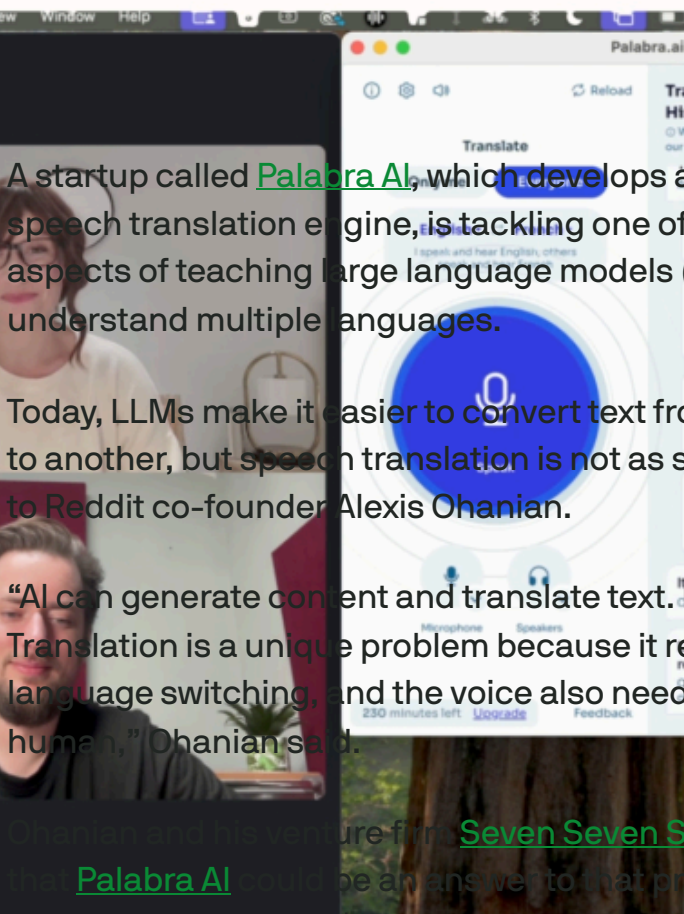
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APPS



AI translation tech Palabra gets backing from Reddit co-founder's venture firm



A startup called [Palabra AI](#), which develops an AI-powered speech translation engine, is tackling one of the more difficult aspects of teaching large language models (LLMs) to understand multiple languages.

Today, LLMs make it easier to convert text from one language to another, but speech translation is not as simple, according to Reddit co-founder Alexis Ohanian.

“AI can generate content and translate text. But [Speech] Translation is a unique problem because it requires real-time language switching, and the voice also needs to sound human,” Ohanian said.

Ohanian and his venture firm, [Seven Seven Six](#) (776) believe that [Palabra AI](#) could be an answer to that problem. That’s why the firm is leading an \$8.4 million pre-seed round into the startup. The round also saw participation from Creator Ventures along with individual investors, including Instacart co-founder Max Mullen, former a16z partner Anne Lee Skates, former DeepMind Head of Product at Mehdi Ghissassi, and Namat Bahram.

IMAGE CREDITS: PALABRA

Seven Seven Six’s Ohanian also noted that Palabra’s combination of product execution and team expertise pushed the firm to invest.

“With Palabra, the translation layer works very smoothly. The company has a strong AI research team that does high-quality work around speech. Plus, the startup has made great choices in product design and quality of output,” he added.

Palabra was founded by Artem Kukharenko and Alexander Kabakov in 2023. Kukharenko, a former machine learning engineer at Samsung, said that he has lived in various countries as a digital nomad and faced problems with languages. That’s why he wanted to combine his machine learning experience to solve for real-time translation.

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CEO ARTEM KUKHARENKO

IMAGE CREDITS: PALABRA

“Many other companies have tried to solve the translation problem. But when they combined different pieces of tech, including speech-to-text and text-to-speech APIs while translating, the latency number increased, and the translation didn't feel real-time. With Palabra, we have been able to bring

down the latency to 800ms, making our translation seamless and real-time,” he told TechCrunch over a call.

Kukhareenko added that the company has built a custom data pipeline to make it easy for the startup to add support for a new language within weeks. He said that at the end of this pipeline, Palabra places a human interpreter who checks for quality of the output. The startup said that its algorithm also accounts for different scenarios like noisy environments and interruptions.

Palabra AI has both consumer and business-facing translation products. The company offers a desktop app — for both Mac and Windows — that works with popular video calling apps, including Google Meet, Zoom, Discord, Slack, and Microsoft Teams. The app can support translation in over 30 languages, which means you can listen to someone speaking in their native tongue in your choice of language. This could be handy for calls that involve participants of various nationalities.

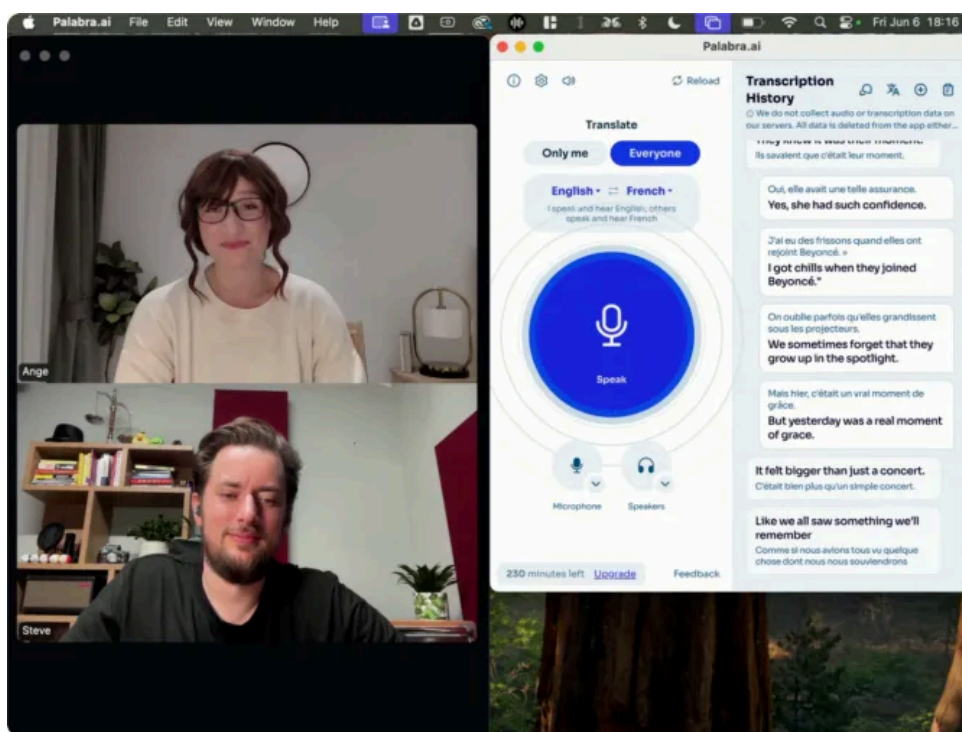


IMAGE CREDITS: PALABRA

On its website, Palabra says that its desktop app will soon support native translation features for content sites like YouTube, Netflix, Twitch, and Vimeo.

You receive 30 minutes of translation free each month. For a higher limit, you can pay for plans starting at \$25 per month for 60 minutes of translation across apps.

The startup provides APIs and SDKs to enterprises to integrate translation into their products.

Currently, its technology is powering video platforms such as Agora for live multilingual streams. Plus, language-service providers like GIS Group are using Palabra's tools alongside human interpreters. The company said multiple event organizers also utilize its tech to provide multilingual streams.

Palabra has tough competition in the translation market. On the consumer end, startups like [Y Combinator-backed EzDubs](#) are building apps that work for in-person or call conversations. Earlier this year, Google also launched [real-time translation for video calls on Meet](#). On the business end of things, startups like [Dubai-based Camb.AI](#) are building translation tech to broadcast live events in multiple languages.

To stand out, Palabra is currently working on a new streaming prediction model, which could result in a drastic drop in latency. It is also working on supporting translation for over 10,000 simultaneous audio streams.

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Ivan Mehta

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously worked at publications including...

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

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Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”



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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not

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even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn’t the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn’t really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn’t think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won’t necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the same beat for Forbes...

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IMAGE CREDITS: EIGHT SLEEP / EIGHT SLEEP

FUNDRAISING



Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Roughly [one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep](#), driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#), founded in 2014, offers AI-powered sleep tech products that promise to transform your bed into a preventive health device.

The New York-based startup announced Tuesday that it raised a fresh \$100 million round from investors such as HSG, Valor Equity Partners, Founders Fund, Y Combinator and athletes including Ferrari F1 driver Charles Leclerc, and Zak Brown, who is the CEO of McLaren F1.

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breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it automatically adjusts temperature, elevation, and firmness. It can also detect snoring and automatically elevate the base in response, according to the company.

The company has generated more than \$500 million in Pod sales, expanded its revenue tenfold since launching the product in 2019, and collected insights from over one billion hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.

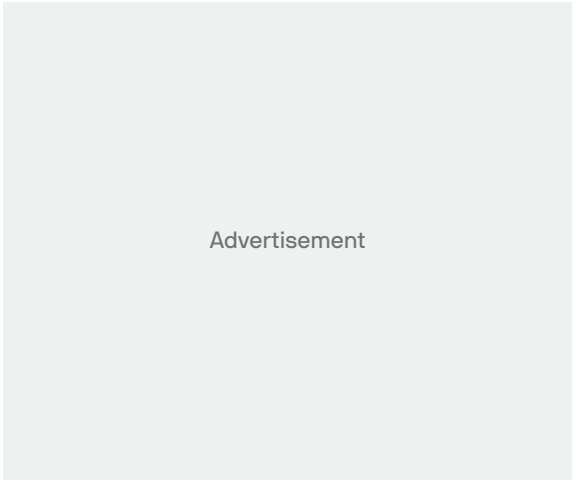
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The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress

and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight's core differentiator, Autopilot, "builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed," Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod's health-monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

"We're not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care," Zatarain said.

Eight's recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod's real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world's largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale's regulations, including for data storage.

"Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don't use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights," Zatarain said.

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Kate Park

Reporter, Asia |

Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She previously was a financial...

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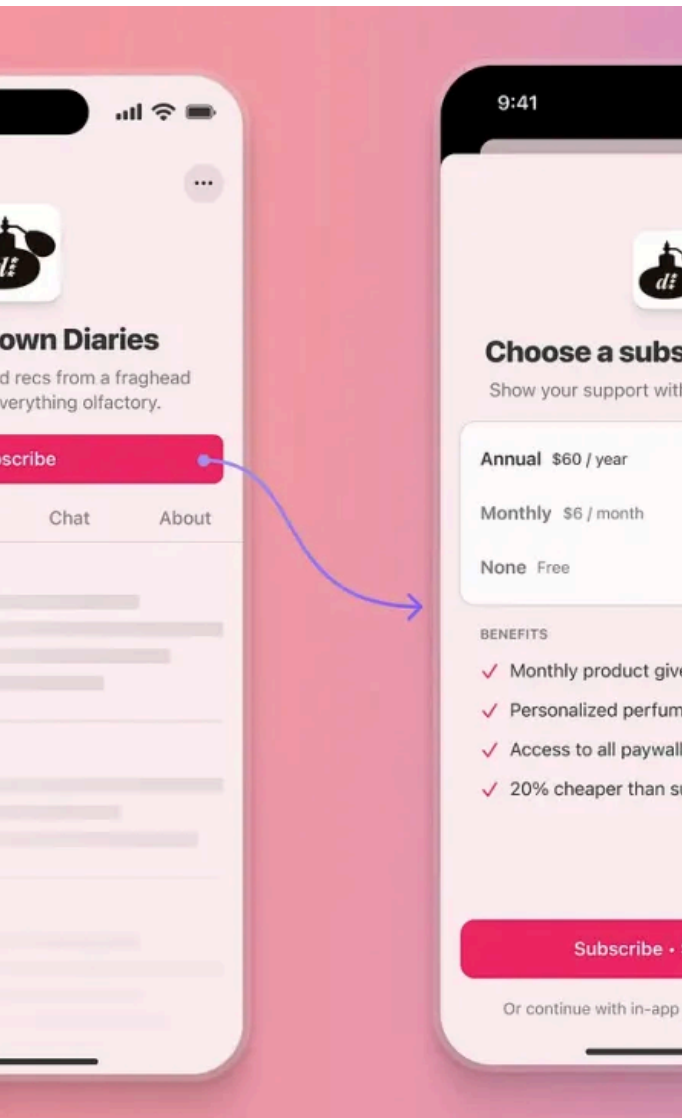


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

APPS



Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-based subscriptions on iOS

Sarah Perez — 10:16 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Newsletter subscription platform Substack will begin taking advantage of an option on the U.S. App Store that allows users

to make purchases outside of Apple's in-app purchasing system. This functionality is permitted by a [change to the App Store's rules in May](#), as a result of [Epic Games' antitrust lawsuit](#) against the tech giant.

Since then, a number of top apps have moved to offer in-app purchase links that point to their own websites, including [Spotify](#), [Patreon](#), and the [Amazon Kindle](#) app, among others.

In Substack's case, support for external payments will benefit both the company, which no longer has to pay the App Store a commission on those web sales, and consumers, who will have access to reduced pricing. Meanwhile, Substack creators will be able to offer their readers the option of whether they want the convenience of Apple's in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.

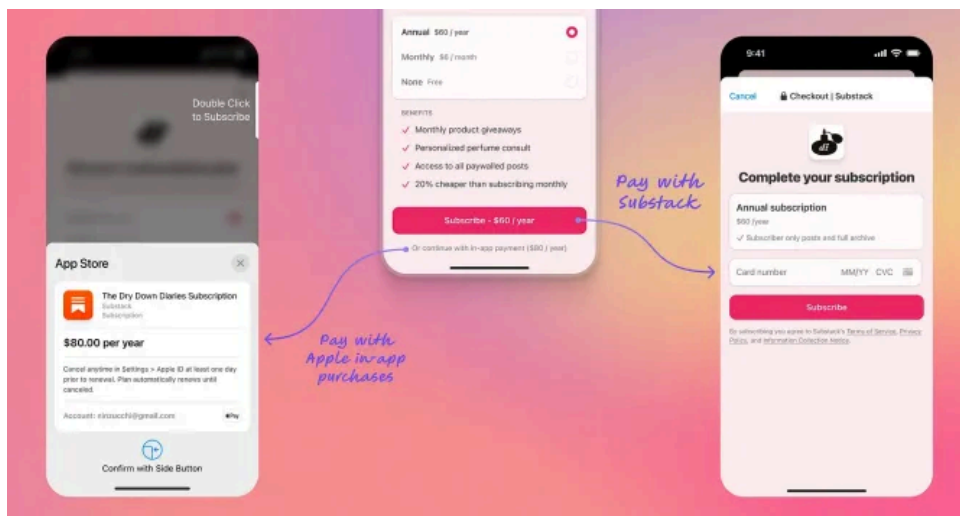


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers' iOS app price higher to account for Apple's fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own 10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it's also offering its writers "migration tools." We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

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Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.

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IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

Per Apple's App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it's still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

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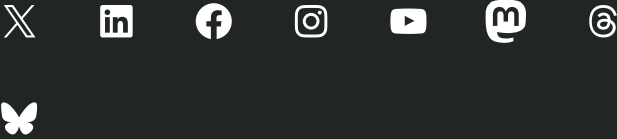
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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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